

SME AI READINESS PLAYBOOK

A Practical Guide for Business Owners
Ready to Stop Guessing and Start Automating.

40

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This playbook is for the SME owner who keeps hearing about AI, maybe tried a few tools, and still isn't sure whether their business is ready — or what "ready" even looks like. By the end, you'll know exactly where you stand, what's holding you back, and what to do next.

Why Most AI Implementations Fail

(And How to Be Different)

Let's start with an uncomfortable truth.

Most small and medium businesses that "try AI" fail at it — not because AI doesn't work, but because they go about it backwards. They see a LinkedIn post. They sign up for three tools in a week, spend a weekend tinkering, get underwhelming results, and conclude that "AI isn't really for businesses like mine."

That's the wrong conclusion. The right conclusion is: **AI requires a foundation.**

You wouldn't hire three new staff members before you had proper job descriptions, onboarding processes, and systems to manage them. AI is no different. If your processes are fuzzy, your data is scattered, and your team doesn't know why change is happening — the smartest AI tool in the world will give you chaos at speed.

This playbook exists to fix that.

The Real Reason AI Fails in Small Business

Here's what we see firsthand working with SMEs across Australia:

Reason #1: Businesses try to automate the wrong things first. Most start with whatever is top of mind — usually something frustrating but not actually high-value. You can't automate your way out of a process problem.

Reason #2: Data is a mess. AI tools are only as smart as the data you feed them. If your customer records live in three different spreadsheets and your CRM is half-updated, you're building on sand.

Reason #3: The team wasn't brought along. Resistance and quiet sabotage are almost guaranteed when AI tools appear without explanation. When leadership doesn't communicate clearly, fear wins.

Reason #4: Expectations are completely wrong. AI is not magic. Business owners who expect a \$99/month tool to replace a full-time employee and triple revenue in 90 days will be disappointed every time.

Reason #5: There's no one driving it. Every successful AI implementation we've seen has had a champion — one person whose job it is to shepherd the change, troubleshoot, and keep momentum going.

The Businesses That Get It Right

- Start with a clear problem to solve, not a tool to try
- Prepare their data and processes before switching anything on

- Communicate openly with their team about what's changing and why
- Set realistic 90-day goals and measure against them
- Get help when they need it rather than burning months figuring it out alone

■ A Note on Language

Throughout this playbook, "AI" refers broadly to artificial intelligence tools — including large language models like Claude and ChatGPT, automation platforms like Zapier and Make, and AI agents capable of multi-step autonomous actions. Everything is explained as we go — no assumed knowledge required.

The AI Readiness Score

Your 20-Question Self-Assessment

This self-assessment gives you a clear, honest picture of where your business stands across five dimensions that matter most for AI success. Take your time. Answer honestly.

How it works

- 20 questions across 5 dimensions (4 questions each)
- Each answer is worth 0, 1, or 2 points
- Maximum possible score: 40 points
- Your total places you in one of four readiness levels

DIMENSION 1

Data Quality

How clean, organised, and accessible is your business data?

Question 1: Where does your customer data live?

- (0) It's spread across emails, spreadsheets, sticky notes, and memory. No single source of truth.
- (1) We have a CRM or database, but it's partially filled in and not regularly maintained.
- (2) We have a CRM or central system that's reasonably complete, regularly updated, and used by the team.

Score: ____

Question 2: How consistent is your data entry across the business?

- (0) Everyone does it differently. No standard.
- (1) We have some guidelines but they're not enforced. Data quality varies a lot.
- (2) We have clear standards for how data is entered, and most of the team follows them consistently.

Score: ____

Question 3: Could you pull a reliable customer list with contact details, purchase history, and last contact date in under 10 minutes?

- (0) No. It would take significant time and effort, and still wouldn't be fully reliable.
- (1) Probably, but it would need cleaning and cross-referencing with a few different sources.
- (2) Yes — we could do this quickly and trust the output.

Score: ____

Question 4: How long do you retain and organise historical business data?

- (0) We don't really have a retention policy. Old data is either lost or buried somewhere inaccessible.
- (1) We keep data, but it's not well organised or easily searchable.
- (2) We keep at least 12 months of clean historical data that's accessible and easy to query.

Score: ____

Dimension 1 Total: ____ / 8

DIMENSION 2

Process Documentation

How well-defined and documented are your core business processes?

Question 5: How are your core business processes documented?

- (0) They live in people's heads. Nothing is written down in any formal way.
- (1) Some key processes are documented, but it's patchy — maybe a few SOPs or a rough onboarding doc.
- (2) Most core processes are documented clearly enough that a new employee could follow them without constant handholding.

Score: ____

Question 6: When a key staff member is away, what happens to their work?

- (0) Things fall through the cracks or someone else scrambles to figure out what to do.
- (1) There's some handover, but it's not smooth. Things slow down noticeably.
- (2) We have clear coverage processes. Work continues with minimal disruption.

Score: ____

Question 7: How well can you describe the exact steps in your most common customer journey?

- (0) I could give you a rough idea, but I'd struggle to list the exact steps in order.
- (1) I know the main steps, but there are gaps, exceptions, and informal workarounds.
- (2) I could map it out clearly, step by step, including who does what and what tools are used.

Score: ____

Question 8: How often do you review and update your business processes?

- (0) Rarely or never. We do what works until it stops working.
- (1) Occasionally — maybe when something breaks or we bring someone new on board.
- (2) Regularly — we treat our processes as living documents and update them as the business evolves.

Score: ____

Dimension 2 Total: ____ / 8

DIMENSION 3

Team Readiness

How prepared is your team for AI-driven change?

Question 9: How would you describe your team's general attitude toward new technology?

- (0) Resistant. New tools usually face pushback, slow adoption, or quiet non-compliance.
- (1) Mixed. Some people are enthusiastic, others cautious or indifferent.
- (2) Generally open. The team adapts to new tools reasonably well when there's a clear reason.

Score: ____

Question 10: Has anyone in your business had meaningful experience using AI tools (ChatGPT, Claude, Copilot, etc.)?

- (0) Not really. Maybe someone's used ChatGPT casually but there's no real AI experience in the team.
- (1) A few people have dabbled, but it hasn't been used in any structured or business-relevant way.
- (2) Yes — at least one person has used AI tools in a business context and understands how to get useful results.

Score: ____

Question 11: How does your business typically handle significant operational change?

- (0) Poorly. Change initiatives tend to stall, get half-implemented, or quietly die after a few weeks.
- (1) It depends on the change. Some stick, some don't. We don't have a strong change management process.
- (2) Reasonably well. We communicate clearly, give people time to adapt, and follow through on implementation.

Score: ____

Question 12: Do you have someone who could champion an AI initiative — drive it, troubleshoot it, and keep momentum going?

- (0) No. It would have to be me (the owner), and I'm already stretched thin.
- (1) Maybe. There's someone who might be able to take it on, but capacity is uncertain.
- (2) Yes. I have at least one person who is technically capable, process-minded, and has bandwidth to lead this.

Score: ____

Dimension 3 Total: ____ / 8

DIMENSION 4

Tech Stack Compatibility

How well does your current technology support AI integration?

Question 13: How would you describe your current software stack?

- (0) A mix of outdated, disconnected, or mostly manual tools. Lots of spreadsheets and workarounds.
- (1) A mix of decent tools, but they don't talk to each other well. Some integration, but not much.
- (2) Reasonably modern cloud-based tools that are either already integrated or easily could be.

Score: ____

Question 14: Do your core business tools have API access or integration capabilities (e.g., Zapier, Make)?

- (0) I honestly don't know, or I know they don't.
- (1) Some of them do, but I haven't explored this much.
- (2) Yes — I know my key tools support integration and I've either used this already or understand how it works.

Score: ____

Question 15: How secure and private is your business data management?

- (0) We don't have formal data security policies. Data handling is ad hoc.
- (1) We take basic precautions (passwords, some access control) but haven't formalised anything.
- (2) We have clear policies around data access, storage, and handling. We're confident our data is secure.

Score: ____

Question 16: How comfortable are you migrating or upgrading software tools when needed?

- (0) It's painful and disruptive. We tend to stick with what we have even when it's not working well.
- (1) We can do it, but it takes significant time and causes disruption.
- (2) It's manageable. We've done it before and have a reasonable approach to transitions.

Score: ____

Dimension 4 Total: ____ / 8

DIMENSION 5

Budget & Timeline Realism

Are your expectations and resources aligned with reality?

Question 17: What is your realistic monthly budget for AI tools and implementation?

- (0) Zero, or close to it. We'd need to see results before committing any spend.
- (1) A small but meaningful amount — somewhere between \$100 and \$500 per month.

(2) \$500 or more per month, and I understand this is an investment that may take 3–6 months to show strong ROI.

Score: ____

Question 18: How much time can you or your team realistically dedicate to AI implementation over the next 90 days?

- (0) Minimal — maybe a few hours total. Everyone is at capacity.
- (1) A few hours per week across the team. Not a lot, but something.
- (2) Meaningful time — at least 2–4 hours per week for one dedicated person, with additional team time for training.

Score: ____

Question 19: What does success with AI look like to you in 12 months?

- (0) I'm not sure. I just know I need to do something with AI or get left behind.
- (1) I have a general sense — "save time" or "handle more customers" — but no specific targets.
- (2) I have specific goals in mind with a rough idea of what measurable improvement would look like.

Score: ____

Question 20: How does your leadership feel about taking an experimental, iterative approach?

- (0) Uncomfortable. We prefer to know something will work before we invest time and money in it.
- (1) Somewhat open, but we'd need to see early wins to maintain confidence.
- (2) Comfortable. We understand that iteration is how you find what works, and we're willing to learn from failures.

Score: ____

Dimension 5 Total: ____ / 8

Your Score Summary

Fill in your totals below:

DIMENSION	YOUR SCORE	MAX SCORE
1. Data Quality	____	8
2. Process Documentation	____	8
3. Team Readiness	____	8
4. Tech Stack Compatibility	____	8
5. Budget & Timeline Realism	____	8
TOTAL	____	40

Your AI Readiness Score: _____ / 40

Scoring Your Results

What Your Score Actually Means

This score is a starting point, not a verdict. A low score means you have preparation work to do first — and that's completely normal. Most SMEs sit in the lower ranges when they first do this assessment.

Pay attention to your lowest dimension, not just your total. A business might score 36/40 overall but have only 2/8 in Data Quality. That single weak area can derail even the best-laid AI plans.

Your score will change. Within 90 days of focused preparation work, most businesses can move up by at least one readiness level.

Score Ranges at a Glance

SCORE	READINESS LEVEL	WHAT IT MEANS
0 – 12	Unplugged	Foundation work needed before any AI investment
13 – 22	Wired	Ready to explore, but key gaps need addressing first
23 – 32	Connected	Good foundation — time to implement strategically
33 – 40	Ignited	Ready to scale and optimise with advanced AI

Understanding Your Dimension Scores

Low Score in Data Quality (0–3/8)

This is the most common bottleneck. Without clean, organised data, AI tools will give you inconsistent and unreliable results. Before doing anything else, get your data in order.

- Identify your single most important data source
- Set a standard for how data gets entered and by whom
- Dedicate time each week to cleaning and consolidating existing records

Low Score in Process Documentation (0–3/8)

You can't automate a process you haven't defined. If your processes live in people's heads, AI will entrench that chaos, not fix it. Map your top 3 workflows before implementing any AI.

- Pick your single most repeated business workflow
- Map it step by step — even a rough flowchart or numbered list is a start
- Identify where the decisions are made and by whom

Low Score in Team Readiness (0–3/8)

Technology is a people problem as much as a technical one. A resistant team will sabotage even excellent tools.

- Have an honest conversation with your team about why AI matters and what it means for them
- Identify your most enthusiastic team member as your internal AI champion
- Start small with a low-stakes tool that makes someone's day genuinely easier

Low Score in Tech Stack Compatibility (0–3/8)

Older or disconnected tools create friction that limits what AI can do. You don't need to overhaul everything at once, but you do need a plan.

- Audit your current tools against cloud-based alternatives
- Check whether your key tools support API, Zapier, or Make integration
- Identify the single biggest integration gap and address it first

Low Score in Budget & Timeline Realism (0–3/8)

Unrealistic expectations are the fastest way to give up too early. AI implementation is an investment — in time, money, and patience.

- Set a realistic 12-month budget for tools + implementation
- Write down one specific goal AI should help you achieve in the next 90 days
- Accept that the first attempt at something rarely works perfectly

The 4 AI Readiness Levels

Where You Fit Right Now

Level 1: Unplugged (Score 0–12)

Who you are: You're running a real business — probably successfully — but largely on intuition, manual processes, and personal relationships. Your systems are informal, your data is scattered.

The honest truth: Right now, introducing AI would be like installing a high-performance engine in a car with no steering wheel. That doesn't mean AI isn't for you. It means you have foundational work to do first — and that work has enormous value regardless of AI.

Primary focus for the next 90 days: Foundation building, not tool adoption.

- Organise your most important data into one place
- Document your top 3 business processes
- Have honest conversations with your team about technology
- Pick one small, low-risk AI tool to experiment with — not to deploy widely, but to build familiarity

What AI looks like for you right now: Start with tools that require no integration. Claude or ChatGPT for writing and thinking tasks. That's it.

Level 2: Wired (Score 13–22)

Who you are: You've got more in place than you might think. You're running on real systems. But there are meaningful gaps. Data quality is inconsistent. Some processes are in people's heads. Your tech tools don't talk to each other much.

The honest truth: You're closer than you think, but the gaps you have are the ones that will trip you up if you rush. A few weeks of targeted preparation can move you to Level 3 faster than you expect.

Primary focus for the next 90 days: Gap-closing, then careful tool selection.

- Identify your two biggest weak spots from the assessment and address them directly
- Pick one high-value, well-defined business process to automate or assist with AI
- Build your team's confidence with one simple, visible AI win before going broader

What AI looks like for you right now: Content creation assistance, meeting summaries, basic chatbot for customer enquiries, simple automation of repetitive admin tasks.

Level 3: Connected (Score 23–32)

Who you are: You have a solid foundation. Your data is reasonably clean. Your processes are documented, at least for the important stuff. Your team can handle change. Your tech stack is mostly cloud-based.

The honest truth: This is where the real gains start. You have enough of a foundation to implement AI in ways that make a measurable difference — not just productivity experiments, but genuine revenue and time impact. Resist the temptation to implement everything at once.

Primary focus for the next 90 days: Strategic, high-value implementation.

- Choose your highest-impact AI use case (customer service, sales, content, or operations — pick one)
- Implement it properly: clean data input, clear process, team training, measurement framework
- Document your results so you can replicate the approach for the next use case

What AI looks like for you right now: CRM-integrated AI for sales follow-up, AI-assisted customer service, automated reporting, AI-generated content at scale.

Level 4: Ignited (Score 33–40)

Who you are: You're ahead of most SMEs in Australia. Your systems are clean, your team is capable, your stack is modern, and you understand that AI is an iterative investment, not a one-time fix.

The honest truth: In 2026, AI agents — tools that take multi-step actions autonomously — have moved from 'advanced' to 'available'. The businesses at this level that fall behind are the ones that get complacent after early wins.

Primary focus for the next 90 days: Scaling, optimising, and building competitive advantage.

- Audit existing AI implementations for ROI — retire what's not delivering
- Explore AI agents for multi-step autonomous workflows
- Build internal AI capability — training, documentation, experimentation culture
- Identify where AI can give you a genuine edge over competitors who haven't yet caught up

What AI looks like for you right now: AI agents, custom integrations, predictive analytics, automated customer journeys, AI-assisted hiring, advanced content personalisation.

The Most Common Mistakes SMEs Make with AI

(And Exactly How to Avoid Them)

These aren't theoretical mistakes. They're patterns we see repeatedly in businesses across industries and sizes.

Mistake #1: Starting with the Tool, Not the Problem

What it looks like: "I heard about this AI tool that does X. Let's implement it." Two weeks later they're not sure what problem it's actually solving.

The fix: Always start with the problem statement. Write it down: "We are losing X hours per week on Y task, which costs us approximately \$Z per month." Then find the tool.

Mistake #2: Implementing AI Before Fixing Broken Processes

What it looks like: A business automates its customer onboarding workflow. The automation works — but the onboarding process itself was confusing and incomplete. Now it's automated confusion.

The fix: Before you automate anything, walk through the process manually and fix the problems first. *Never automate a process you haven't already simplified.*

Mistake #3: Ignoring Data Quality

What it looks like: A business implements AI to personalise customer communications. The AI starts sending emails to "Dear [FIRST NAME]" because half the customer records don't have first names.

The fix: Before any AI implementation that relies on existing data, do a data quality audit. Pull a random sample of 50 records and check completeness and formatting.

Mistake #4: Not Getting Buy-In from the Team

What it looks like: The business owner comes back from a conference excited about AI. They implement a new tool within a week. Staff feel blindsided and passively resistant. Six months later, the tool is technically "live" but barely used.

The fix: Include your team from the start. Ask them where they spend the most time on repetitive tasks. Frame AI as something that removes the tedious stuff, not their jobs.

Mistake #5: Treating AI as "Set and Forget"

What it looks like: A business implements a chatbot. It works well for the first month. Over time, it starts giving outdated information and frustrating customers. Nobody updated it.

The fix: Every AI implementation needs an owner — a human responsible for reviewing performance and making adjustments monthly. Treat it like a team member who needs occasional feedback.

Mistake #6: Trying to Do Everything at Once

What it looks like: Excited by the possibilities, a business implements a new CRM, an AI chatbot, an email automation tool, and a reporting dashboard — all in the same quarter. Six weeks later, nothing works well.

The fix: Pick one use case, implement it properly, measure the results, then move to the next. One well-configured AI tool your team actually uses is worth ten half-implemented ones nobody trusts.

Mistake #7: Underestimating the Time Required

What it looks like: A business owner allocates "a few hours on the weekend" to get an AI tool running. Setup is incomplete, team hasn't been trained, outputs are mediocre. They conclude the tool isn't worth it.

The fix: For any meaningful AI implementation, budget 2–4 weeks of part-time effort for initial setup, testing, and team training. Then budget ongoing time for monthly reviews.

Mistake #8: Not Measuring Anything

What it looks like: A business implements AI for content creation. The owner has a vague sense it's saving time. Twelve months later, when someone asks whether the AI investment was worth it, there's no answer.

The fix: Before you implement any AI tool, write down your baseline. How long does the task currently take? How much does it cost? Measure the same metrics three months after implementation.

Mistake #9: Ignoring Data Privacy and Security

What it looks like: A business starts feeding customer data — names, emails, purchase history — into an AI tool without reading the terms of service or understanding how that data is stored.

The fix: Before putting any customer data into an AI tool, read the privacy policy. Key questions: Where is the data stored? Is it used to train the AI? Is it compliant with the Australian Privacy Act?

Mistake #10: Expecting AI to Replace Human Judgement

What it looks like: A business uses AI to screen job applications. The AI filters candidates based on keyword matching. Several excellent candidates are eliminated. The business hires someone mediocre.

The fix: Use AI to assist human decision-making, not replace it — especially for decisions that significantly affect people. Treat AI outputs as a first draft or first filter, not a final answer.

Your 90-Day AI Readiness Roadmap

Personalised by Readiness Level

Find your level from Section 3 and follow the corresponding plan. Each roadmap breaks into three 30-day phases: **Foundation** → **Experiment** → **Measure & Expand**.

Roadmap A: Unplugged (Score 0–12)

You're building from the ground up. Don't rush. The work you do in these 90 days will pay dividends for years.

Month 1: Foundation

Week 1–2: Data Triage

- Identify your single most important data category (usually customer contact records or sales history)
- Pull every source of that data you can find — spreadsheets, email, memory
- Consolidate it into one place — a spreadsheet is fine for now
- Remove duplicates, fill in obvious gaps, standardise the format
- Goal: A single, reasonably clean list of your top 50–100 customers or recent transactions

Week 3–4: Process Mapping

- Pick the one business process that happens most often and has the most steps
- Sit down with anyone involved and map every step in order
- Note who does each step, what tool they use, and roughly how long it takes
- Identify the top 3 pain points where things go wrong or slow down
- Goal: A one-page process map, even if rough. This document is gold.

Month 2: Experiment

Week 5–6: Team Conversation

- Schedule 30 minutes with your team or key staff
- Explain what you're working on and which specific task you're targeting
- "What takes the most time in your week that feels repetitive?" — take notes
- "This is about removing the tedious stuff, not replacing people"
- Goal: Understand your team's perspective. Identify one task they'd love to see automated.

Week 7–8: First AI Experiment

- Option A: Use Claude or ChatGPT to draft email templates for your 3 most common customer communications

- Option B: Use Fireflies.ai or Otter.ai to record and transcribe your next three client meetings
- Option C: Use Claude to create a simple FAQ document from your most common customer questions
- Do this personally first. Learn the tool before handing it to your team.
- Goal: One completed AI experiment that produced something genuinely useful.

Month 3: Measure & Expand

Week 9–10: Evaluate and Document

- Compare the quality and time cost of your AI experiment vs the old way
- Write a one-paragraph summary: what worked, what didn't, what you'd do differently
- Share the result with your team — transparency builds trust

Week 11–12: Plan Your Next 90 Days

- Re-take the readiness assessment. Has your score improved?
- Identify your two biggest remaining gaps
- Set a concrete goal for the next 90 days
- Consider whether you need external help to move faster (see Section 8)

Roadmap B: Wired (Score 13–22)

You have a workable foundation. Your focus is on closing the most important gaps and implementing one high-value AI use case properly.

Month 1: Foundation

Week 1–2: Targeted Gap Assessment

- Data Quality gap: Run a 50-record audit on your primary data source. Note error rates. Fix them. Establish a data entry standard.
- Process Documentation gap: Choose your most important client-facing process. Map it end to end in a shared doc.
- Team Readiness gap: Hold a 45-minute team meeting with three examples of AI helping similar businesses.
- Tech Stack gap: Audit your current tools. Check which integrate with Zapier or Make.
- Goal: Two specific gap areas addressed with a concrete artefact.

Week 3–4: Define Your First Use Case

- Choose one and only one use case for your first AI implementation
- Criteria: High frequency, significant time cost, predictable inputs/outputs, low risk if it goes slightly wrong
- Goal: One clearly defined use case written down — the problem, the current process, the expected AI-assisted process, and how you'll measure success.

Month 2: Experiment

Week 5–6: Tool Selection and Setup

- Research 2–3 tools that address your chosen use case specifically
- Prioritise tools that offer a free trial, have good documentation, and integrate with tools you already use
- Set up your chosen tool properly — read the documentation. Most tools have 1–3 hours of proper setup time.

Week 7–8: Controlled Rollout

- Start with yourself or one team member — not the whole team
- Run the AI-assisted process in parallel with the old process for two weeks
- Keep a simple log: date, task, time taken with AI, quality rating (1–5)
- Goal: Two weeks of parallel testing data. Enough to know if the tool is worth expanding.

Month 3: Measure & Expand

Week 9–10: Review and Decide

- Analyse your parallel testing data
- Calculate time saved, quality comparison, and team sentiment
- Make a go/no-go decision on expanding to the full team
- If yes: create a simple one-page training document

Week 11–12: Team Rollout and Next Use Case

- Train your team on the new tool (30-minute session is usually enough)
- Assign an "AI champion" who owns ongoing performance and maintenance
- Begin planning your second use case
- Goal: One AI tool properly deployed, measured, and owned. One new use case planned.

Use Case Ideas by Business Type

BUSINESS TYPE	STRONG FIRST USE CASE
Professional services	Client proposal drafting
Retail / ecommerce	Product description writing & customer emails
Trade / services	Job scheduling and dispatch communications
Healthcare / allied health	Patient communications and appointment reminders
Hospitality	Menu copy, booking responses, review management
Consulting / coaching	Content creation and follow-up emails

Roadmap C: Connected (Score 23–32)

You're ready for real impact. Your focus is on strategic, high-value implementation with proper measurement and team capability building.

Month 1: Strategic AI Audit

Week 1–2: Audit and Prioritise

- List every software tool currently in your stack — does it have an AI feature you're not using?
- Identify your top 3 highest-cost, most time-consuming processes
- Prioritise by: $(\text{time cost} \times \text{frequency}) \div \text{implementation complexity}$

Week 3–4: Data Architecture Review

- Are your key tools syncing data reliably (CRM, accounting, communications)?
- Any data silos limiting your visibility?
- Set up a simple reporting dashboard if you don't have one (Google Looker Studio is free)

Month 2: Flagship Implementation

Week 5–8: Build and Test

- Choose your highest-impact use case and implement it properly
- Options: AI customer service chatbot, AI-assisted CRM follow-up sequences, systematic AI content production, automated reporting
- Map the current process end to end. Identify which steps AI handles and which require human input.
- Build and test before going live. Set up measurement from day one.

Month 3: Measure, Train, and Scale

Week 9–12: Optimise and Document

- Compare baseline vs current performance on your target metric
- Optimise the 20% of things causing 80% of problems
- Run an internal training session: 2–3 hours, focused on practical AI skills your team can use now
- Create an internal "AI playbook" — tools, how to use them, prompts that work
- Build a 6-month AI roadmap: which use cases are next, what investment is required

Roadmap D: Ignited (Score 33–40)

You're in a strong position. Your focus is on scaling, optimising, and building sustainable competitive advantage.

Month 1: Audit and Prioritise

Week 1–2: Comprehensive ROI Audit

- For every AI tool currently in use: What metric was it meant to improve? Has it? What's the monthly cost?
- Retire anything not delivering measurable value. Consolidate overlapping capabilities.
- Research what AI adoption looks like in your specific industry

Week 3–4: Competitive Intelligence

- Identify 2–3 capabilities not yet standard in your market but becoming so
- These are your differentiation opportunities — be early, not late

Month 2: AI Agents and Advanced Implementations

Week 5–8: Next-Level Use Cases

- AI agents are now mainstream in 2026 — tools that take multi-step actions autonomously with defined guardrails
- Custom integrations: purpose-built connections between your tools and AI capabilities
- Predictive analytics: use historical data to forecast demand, identify at-risk customers, flag operational bottlenecks
- Personalisation at scale: AI-driven customer communication that adapts to individual behaviour
- Choose one. Plan it properly. Build with a clear brief, defined success metrics, and a review date.

Month 3: Build Your AI Operating System

Week 9–12: Systematise

- AI policy document: how your business uses AI, what data can go into public tools, what stays internal
- Continuous learning practice: one AI-focused learning activity per month for you and your team
- Innovation pipeline: a running list of AI use cases to explore, with a quarterly review
- External expertise relationship: a consultant or advisor who keeps you current and helps avoid expensive mistakes

Tool Stack Recommendations by Budget

\$0 / ~\$500/mo / ~\$2,000/mo

The right tools depend on your budget, your use cases, and your technical capacity. Every tool listed has been selected for practical value, ease of use, and suitability for Australian SMEs.

■ Note on pricing

Prices shown are approximate AUD figures as of mid-2026. Always check current pricing at the provider's website. Most tools offer 14–30 day free trials — use them before committing.

Budget Tier 1: \$0/month — Start Free

For businesses just getting started, or those who want to build confidence before committing any spend. This stack is genuinely powerful.

TOOL	WHAT IT DOES BEST	IDEAL FOR
ChatGPT (Free)	General-purpose AI assistant	Writing, research, brainstorming, drafting emails
Claude (Free)	Strong reasoning & long context	Complex analysis, nuanced writing, long documents
Google Gemini (Free)	AI integrated with Google Workspace	Gmail drafting, Docs assistance, research
Otter.ai (Free tier)	Meeting transcription & notes	Recording and summarising meetings and calls
Canva (Free)	AI-assisted design	Social media graphics, presentations, marketing materials
Notion AI (trial)	AI-assisted documentation	Process docs, meeting notes, knowledge base
Google Looker Studio	Reporting and dashboards	Business reporting from Google Sheets & Analytics

Realistic outcome: 3–5 hours per week saved on writing and communication tasks. Measurably better quality written outputs.

Budget Tier 2: ~\$500/month

For businesses ready to invest in proper tools that integrate with their existing stack and deliver meaningful time savings.

TOOL	PURPOSE	APPROX. COST/MO (AUD)
ChatGPT Plus or Claude Pro	Advanced AI for the whole team	\$35–70
Zapier (Starter)	Automation between your tools	\$30–80
HubSpot CRM (Starter)	CRM with AI features for sales follow-up	\$50–100
Notion AI	Team knowledge base & documentation	\$15–30
Fireflies.ai	AI meeting notes + CRM integration	\$20–40
Buffer or Publer	AI-assisted social media scheduling	\$20–40
Loom	Async team communication via video	\$15
Contingency / extras	New tools, trials, add-ons	\$100–150

Realistic outcome: 8–12 hours per week saved across the team. A functioning automated sales follow-up process.

Budget Tier 3: ~\$2,000/month

For established businesses ready to use AI as a genuine competitive advantage — automating complex workflows and building scalable customer experiences.

TOOL	PURPOSE	APPROX. COST/MO (AUD)
ChatGPT Team or Claude Team	AI for all staff with privacy controls	\$100–200
Make (formerly Integromat) Pro	Advanced automation & multi-step workflows	\$100–200
HubSpot Professional	Full CRM, marketing automation, AI insights	\$400–900
Intercom or Freshdesk	AI-powered customer service chatbot	\$100–300
Databox or Klipfolio	Advanced business intelligence dashboards	\$100–200
Fireflies.ai Business	AI meeting intelligence & CRM integration	\$40–80
Grammarly Business	Writing quality for all team communications	\$50–100
Custom AI / Retainer	Specialist help, custom integrations	\$200–500

Realistic outcome: 20+ hours per week saved across the team. Automated customer acquisition and nurture sequences. A genuine operational edge.

When to DIY vs When to Get Help

The honest answer isn't the same for every business. Here's a framework for making the call.

FACTOR	DIY	GET HELP
Complexity	Simple, single-tool setup	Multi-tool integration or custom development
Time	Plenty of available time	Time-poor, need results quickly
Technical skill	Comfortable with software setup	Mostly non-technical team
Stakes	Low-risk internal tools	Customer-facing or revenue-critical systems
Budget	Tight — minimise spend	Budget available, prioritising speed and quality
Learning value	Want to build internal capability	Want the result, not the learning curve

Strong Cases for DIY

Experimenting with writing tools. Claude, ChatGPT, and similar tools are built for non-technical users. Anyone comfortable with email can learn to use them effectively.

Setting up simple automations between popular tools. Zapier's interface is designed for non-developers. Connecting two mainstream tools is something most business owners can handle with an afternoon of learning.

The use case is internal and low-stakes. Experimenting with AI for internal processes — meeting notes, internal drafts, team communication — carries low risk. Use these to build confidence and skills.

You have time and a technically capable team member. If you have someone technically capable with bandwidth to learn, investing in their skills is often better long-term than outsourcing.

Strong Cases for Getting Help

Customer-facing systems are involved. If AI is going to interact with your customers, get it right the first time. A bad customer experience is worse than no AI experience.

You need multiple tools to work together seamlessly. Once you're connecting three or more tools in a meaningful workflow, complexity increases significantly. Mistakes at the integration level are hard to diagnose.

You're making significant monthly commitments. If you're evaluating tools at the \$500–2,000+/month level, the cost of getting selection and setup wrong is substantial. A few hours with an experienced consultant can save months of wasted spend.

You've tried DIY and it's not working. There's no shame in trying something yourself and then getting help when you hit a wall. What you've learned will make you a much better client.

Your time is worth a lot. If you're billing at \$200+/hour, spending 20 hours learning a tool that a specialist could configure in 4 hours is a \$3,200 opportunity cost.

■ The Ignition Agency Approach

This is exactly how we work. We start with your business problem, not our favourite tools. We build solutions your team can understand and own. And we measure everything.

If you want to explore whether we're the right fit, there's a free 30-minute audit available at ignitionagency.au — details in Section 10.

AI Prompt Library

10 Ready-to-Use Prompts

These 10 prompts are written for SME business contexts. Copy them, adapt the [BRACKETS] to your business, and start using them today in Claude (claude.ai) or ChatGPT (chat.openai.com) — both have free versions.

How to use these prompts

1. Open Claude or ChatGPT
2. Copy the prompt below
3. Replace [BRACKETS] with your specific information
4. Paste and send
5. Review, refine, iterate — rarely is the first output perfect, but it's almost always a strong starting point

Prompt 1: Customer Enquiry Response

Use case: Responding to a common customer question professionally and thoroughly.

The Prompt:

You are a friendly, professional customer service representative for [BUSINESS NAME], a [BUSINESS TYPE] based in [LOCATION].

A customer has sent the following enquiry:
"[PASTE CUSTOMER ENQUIRY HERE]"

Write a response that:

- Addresses their question directly and completely
- Is warm but professional in tone
- Includes a clear next step for the customer
- Is between 100-150 words
- Does not use jargon or overly formal language

Our key services include: [LIST YOUR MAIN SERVICES]

Our standard turnaround time is: [YOUR TURNAROUND TIME]

Prompt 2: Proposal Cover Letter

Use case: Writing the opening page of a quote or proposal.

The Prompt:

Write a professional but warm proposal cover letter for a quote I'm sending to [CLIENT NAME], who runs [BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THEIR BUSINESS].

They came to us with the following problem or need:
[DESCRIBE WHAT THEY NEED IN 2-3 SENTENCES]

Our proposed solution is:
[BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF WHAT YOU'RE PROPOSING]

Key benefits we're offering:
[LIST 3-4 MAIN BENEFITS]

Tone: confident, consultative, and personal – not salesy. Australian English.
Maximum 200 words.

Prompt 3: Job Advertisement

Use case: Writing a job ad that attracts the right candidates.

The Prompt:

Write a job advertisement for the following role at our company.

Company: [COMPANY NAME]
Business type: [WHAT YOU DO]
Location: [LOCATION] (remote/hybrid/in-office)
Role title: [JOB TITLE]
Employment type: [Full-time / Part-time / Casual / Contract]

Key responsibilities:
[LIST 4-6 MAIN RESPONSIBILITIES]

What we're looking for:
[LIST SKILLS, EXPERIENCE, AND PERSONALITY TRAITS]

What we offer:
[SALARY RANGE, PERKS, CULTURE HIGHLIGHTS]

Write a job ad that sounds human and genuine, not like a corporate HR template.
Australian English. Around 300 words.

Prompt 4: Social Media Post Series

Use case: Creating a week's worth of social media content quickly.

The Prompt:

Create 5 social media posts for [PLATFORM] for my business, [BUSINESS NAME].

We are a [BUSINESS TYPE] that helps [TARGET CUSTOMER] achieve [MAIN OUTCOME].

Here are 5 topics I want to cover this week:

1. [TOPIC 1]
2. [TOPIC 2]
3. [TOPIC 3]
4. [TOPIC 4]
5. [TOPIC 5]

For each post:

- Write the full post text (appropriate length for [PLATFORM])
- Include a relevant question or call to action at the end
- Use a natural, conversational tone – not corporate or promotional
- Australian English. Maximum 3 hashtags per post.

Prompt 5: Meeting Agenda

Use case: Preparing a structured agenda before a client or team meeting.

The Prompt:

I have a [LENGTH] meeting coming up with [WHO].

Purpose of the meeting: [WHAT YOU'RE TRYING TO ACHIEVE]

Background context:

[2-3 SENTENCES ABOUT THE SITUATION OR RELATIONSHIP]

Key topics I need to cover:

[LIST 3-6 TOPICS]

Create a structured meeting agenda that:

- Opens with a clear purpose statement
- Allocates time to each agenda item
- Includes space for questions and next steps
- Ends with a clear summary of actions and owners

Prompt 6: Email Newsletter

Use case: Writing a monthly or fortnightly email newsletter to your customer list.

The Prompt:

Write an email newsletter for [BUSINESS NAME]'s subscriber list.

Our business: [BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF WHAT YOU DO AND WHO YOU SERVE]

This edition's main topic: [MAIN TOPIC OR STORY]

Additional items to include:

- [ITEM 2, e.g., "A useful tip for our audience"]
- [ITEM 3, e.g., "A recent project or case study we're proud of"]
- [ITEM 4, e.g., "A promotion or offer running this month"]

Tone: warm, helpful, and human. Like a trusted expert writing to a friend.

Length: approximately 400 words. Provide 3 subject line options. Australian English.

Prompt 7: Difficult Customer Response

Use case: Responding to a complaint or difficult customer situation professionally.

The Prompt:

A customer has sent the following complaint:

"[PASTE THEIR MESSAGE]"

The situation from our perspective is:

[EXPLAIN WHAT HAPPENED AND ANY RELEVANT CONTEXT]

Our preferred resolution is:

[WHAT YOU'RE ABLE OR WILLING TO OFFER]

Write a professional, empathetic response that:

- Acknowledges their experience without being defensive
- Takes appropriate responsibility (without admitting liability where not warranted)
- Offers the resolution clearly
- Maintains the relationship wherever possible
- Is calm, measured, and human in tone
- Australian English. Maximum 200 words.

Prompt 8: Process Documentation (SOP)

Use case: Turning a messy, verbal process into a clear written SOP.

The Prompt:

I'm going to describe a business process in rough, informal terms. Turn it into a clear Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) that a new employee could follow.

Here is my rough description:

[DESCRIBE THE PROCESS VERBALLY – don't worry about structure or completeness, just brain-dump it]

Please produce an SOP that includes:

- Process name and purpose
- Who is responsible for each step
- Step-by-step instructions in numbered format
- Any tools, templates, or systems used at each step
- Decision points (if X, then Y)
- Common mistakes to avoid
- A "how to know you've done it right" checklist at the end

Prompt 9: Competitive Positioning Statement

Use case: Articulating why customers should choose you over competitors.

The Prompt:

Help me write a clear, compelling positioning statement for my business.

Business name: [NAME]

What we do: [BRIEF DESCRIPTION]

Our target customer: [WHO YOU SERVE – be specific]

The main problem we solve: [THE PRIMARY PAIN POINT YOU ADDRESS]

How we solve it differently: [YOUR APPROACH / WHAT MAKES YOU DIFFERENT]

What results do customers typically get: [OUTCOMES, WITH NUMBERS IF YOU HAVE THEM]

Write:

1. A one-sentence positioning statement (for introductions and headers)
2. A short paragraph (3-4 sentences) for our website About or Services page
3. A 30-second verbal pitch for "what do you do?"

Tone: Confident, clear, benefit-focused. Not corporate. Australian English.

Prompt 10: 90-Day Plan Summary

Use case: Turning a set of goals and priorities into a structured 90-day plan you can actually use.

The Prompt:

I need to create a practical 90-day plan for my business.

Business context: [BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF YOUR BUSINESS AND CURRENT SITUATION]

My three most important goals for the next 90 days are:

1. [GOAL 1]
2. [GOAL 2]
3. [GOAL 3]

Current constraints:

- Time available: [E.G., '10 hours per week for this work']
- Budget: [E.G., '\$500/month']
- Team: [E.G., 'just me, with one part-time assistant']

Create a 90-day plan that:

- Breaks into three 30-day phases (Foundation / Build / Optimise)
- Lists the 3-5 most important actions for each month
- Is realistic given my constraints (don't overload it)
- Includes a success metric for each goal
- Highlights any critical dependencies or risks

Format as a clear, easy-to-follow document I can share with my team.

■ Saving Your Best Prompts

When you find a prompt that works really well for your business, save it somewhere accessible — a Google Doc, a Notion page, or even a simple Notes file. Build your own prompt library over time. The prompts you develop and refine yourself, tailored to your specific business and voice, will be among your most valuable AI assets.

Next Steps

+ Your Free Ignition Audit

You've made it through the whole playbook. That already puts you in the top tier of business owners taking AI seriously.

Your Immediate Next Steps

Step 1: Calculate your score

If you haven't done the self-assessment in Section 2 yet, go back and do it now. Your score shapes everything else — the roadmap you follow, the tools you prioritise, the help you seek.

Step 2: Identify your lowest dimension

Look at your five dimension scores. The lowest one is your biggest bottleneck. Even if your total score is reasonable, a single very low dimension can hold back your entire AI implementation. Start there.

Step 3: Choose one thing from your roadmap to do this week

Not ten things. One thing. What's the first action for Week 1 of your roadmap? Do that. Not next month. This week.

Step 4: Try one prompt from the library

Open Claude or ChatGPT right now (both free). Pick the prompt most relevant to your current work. Spend 15 minutes with it. You'll walk away with something useful.

About Ignition Agency

Ignition Agency helps Australian SMEs implement AI in ways that actually work — not flashy demos, not overpromised outcomes, but practical implementations that deliver measurable time savings, cost reductions, and revenue impact.

We work with businesses that are serious about getting this right. That means starting with your problem, not our favourite tool. Building things your team can understand and own. And measuring everything.

- Business owners with 5–50 staff
- Revenue between \$500K and \$10M
- Across professional services, trades, retail, health, and consulting
- Ready to invest in proper implementation rather than endless experimentation

YOUR FREE 30-MINUTE AI READINESS AUDIT

In 30 minutes, we'll review your AI Readiness Score, identify your highest-value opportunity, and give you a clear, specific first step.

No sales pressure. No obligation. Just an honest conversation.

ignitionagency.au/audit

hello@ignitionagency.au

"The best time to prepare your business for AI was two years ago. The second best time is right now — but only if you do it properly." — Ignition Agency

The businesses that will gain the most from AI over the next five years won't necessarily be the ones that adopted it earliest. They'll be the ones that adopted it thoughtfully — with a clear problem to solve, a solid foundation underneath them, and the patience to iterate their way to something that genuinely works.

You've taken the first step by reading this playbook. Now do the work. We're here if you need us.

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